

Perception

Given that visual processing happens in microseconds, it is not surprising that our brain sometimes struggles to make sense of the information sent by our eyes and so makes us doubt what we are seeing.

Processing a scene

When we look at a scene, we are not really taking it all in. Instead, the eyes repeatedly scan a sequence of thumbnail-sized areas that the brain considers points of interest. The rest of the scene blurs until attention falls onto a new area. Faces tend to be the main focus of a scene—the brain is programmed to look for faces, hence the tendency to see them in the unlikeliest of places, such as the scorch marks on a slice of toast. While details of the target objects are being scrutinized, the conscious brain puts together the story of the scene, complete with the context of each object.

Scanning for details

Looking at a complex picture, such as this café scene, activates processes that distinguish target objects, such as people, from the background and then selects which bits of the target to focus on.

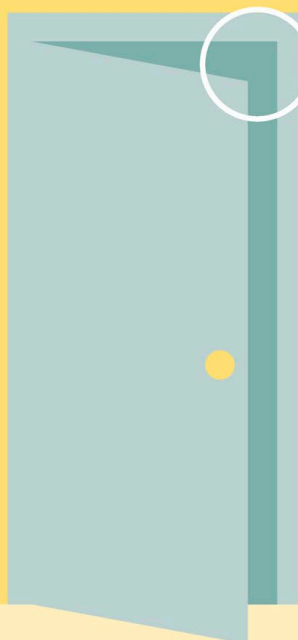
WHY DO WE SEE FACES IN INANIMATE OBJECTS?

Pareidolia (seeing faces where there are none) may be a survival instinct that ensures we are vigilant for the unfriendly features of an enemy or predator.

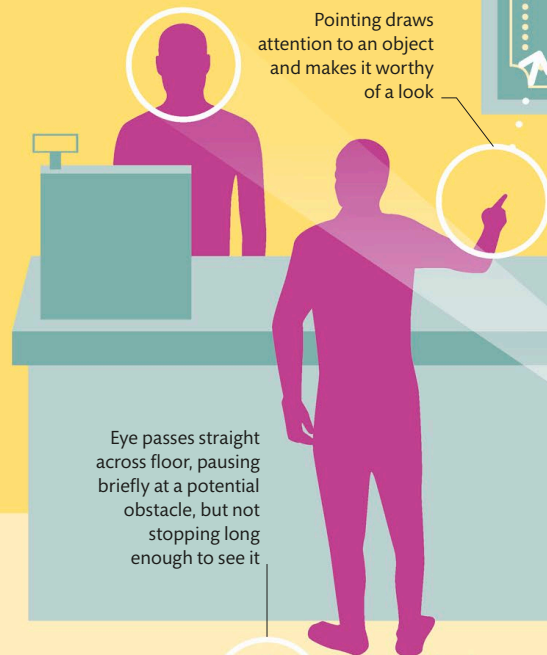
Brain is so drawn to faces that even pictures are studied



Openings are scanned, perhaps for possibility of intruders



Pointing draws attention to an object and makes it worthy of a look



Eye passes straight across floor, pausing briefly at a potential obstacle, but not stopping long enough to see it

Brain looks for clues about relationships by looking at individual faces and interplay between characters

